

Grace with Hard People

DURATION	35–40 min · Week 5
OBJECTIVE	Students articulate strategies for extending grace to people who are difficult — without becoming a doormat.
CASEL FOCUS	Relationship Skills: extending grace from strength · Social Awareness: distinguishing difficult from unsafe
VOCABULARY	difficult, hard, unsafe, distance, dignity
MATERIALS	Anchor chart (Grace vs. Doormat from L1) · Journals · Scenario cards

OPENING REVIEW

2 Minutes

Reference the Grace vs. Doormat anchor chart from L1. “We said grace is not the same as letting people treat you badly. Today we look at the hardest case: how do you extend grace to someone who is genuinely difficult — without becoming the doormat?”

1

Difficult vs. Unsafe

2–10 MIN

DIFFICULT = hard to be around, sometimes unkind, can be navigated with care. UNSAFE = repeatedly causes harm, threatens your wellbeing, requires distance and adult support. Grace applies to difficult. NOT to unsafe. Adult support and limits apply to unsafe.

2

Strategies for Grace with Difficult People

10–20 MIN

(1) Extend the benefit of the doubt — once. (2) Limit your exposure rather than your kindness. (3) Refuse to retaliate without becoming a doormat. (4) Hold dignity — yours and theirs.

3

Scenario Practice

20–30 MIN

Walk through scenarios where grace is the right call vs. distance is the right call. Use the limit formula from the strand lesson when needed.

4

Journal

30–37 MIN

Is there a difficult person in your life? What would extending grace look like — without losing yourself?

IN-LESSON SCAN

During the journal: a student who describes someone who sounds clearly unsafe (not just difficult) — repeated harm, fear, isolation — needs a private check-in. The lesson's strategies are not the right tool for unsafe relationships.